SOCIETY & TRENDS | Teenage Dystopia

SOUL ECLIPSE: Why our children are self-harming, how to fix it. Insights on the teenage depression epidemic in India

COPING WITH ANGST

Teenage depression and self-harm tendencies have existed for decades, but it's something about modern lifestyles that has worsened their impact. "We have fractured ourselves in some ways. Consumerism and digitisation have given a sense of 'I'm not perfect'. There are photoshopped images of a happy, perfect life everywhere," says Abha Adams, an educator and author, whose latest book talks about parenting in the age of anxiety. "At the core of communication is the need to accept—'I see you, I hear you and I accept you for who you are'."

Nupur Dhingra Paiva, a clinical psychologist, agrees. She points out that young people struggle to be taken seriously even when they are suffering or in pain. "Whether it's family or schools or institutions, we don't really know what to do with distress. We think a pill will help us feel better," says Paiva. Often, when there is no answer to their pain, children are left not only overwhelmed and confused but can also turn to self-harm. Psychology student Pranavi Khandekar's account of her battle with depression is telling. She was in so much pain internally, she says, that often, not knowing how to cope with it, she could go from sleeping all day to not sleeping at all. "Some days, I would be so numb, I would cut myself just to see if I am okay and whether I can still feel something," says Paiva. It was only when she was taken to therapy that she was able to make peace with her emotions.

Parents don't have it simple either, and may often end up wasting too much time before getting mental health support for their child. But as Sudipto Patra, whose child was diagnosed with Attention-deficit/ Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD), says, good mental health takes effort. "One of the first things to remember is to allow children to remain children. I know it's a simple thing to say and a complex thing to live. But don't pin the future on them," he says. According to Paiva, the rule of thumb for parents must be to take all distress seriously. If there are signs of anxiety, depression, or even if your child simply says that they are unhappy, it should be dealt with gently and with concern. "After that, we can talk about how, when and where." ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Children often feel they are not taken seriously when they speak of their mental distress. In the absence of support, they can resort to self-harm or unhealthy lifestyles to cope with their emotions
- Rampant consumerism and digitisation have fractured our society by putting immense pressure on those who feel that they are not as perfect as the photoshopped images of happy, flawless lives they see everywhere on the internet
- Therapy and medication can help mental health patients deal with their emotions and not get overwhelmed with negative emotions
- It's important for children to feel accepted and valued. Parents should not pin the future on them or put pressure to be someone they are not
- Showing affection and support when your child talks about their mental health is important. If there are symptoms of depression or anxiety, parents must seek support immediately